The attitude of the Myanmar state towards its Rohingya minority has already crossed many of the lines from ethnic conflict towards genocide. The way the state thinks about this minority is also fundamentally racist, and more than that, the Rohingyas are now seen to be an existential threat to the chosen religious identity of the state. The events since 2012 can be seen as testing the limits of what is deemed acceptable both by Myanmar's society and the wider international community, and are comparable to the build up to genocide we have seen in the other examples discussed. As such, it seems the only thing missing is a trigger for outright genocide.

## Potential triggers

The situation could escalate for any number of reasons, some even apparently unrelated. One could be an unexpected natural disaster, leaving the regime under pressure and desperate to find a scapegoat. Equally, there will be repeats of the 2015 exodus by sea of both willing refugees and those forced to flee. It is not impossible that neighbouring states could close their borders,[5] partly in an attempt to force Myanmar to face up to its responsibilities towards its own population. The situation for the Rohingyas is now so bad that anything from natural disaster to loss of food supplies to the regime lashing out at external pressure could set off a genocide.

What is clear is that the return of limited democracy since 2010 has done nothing to reduce the risks. This section starts with the dynamics around the 2015 election. In part, this allows us to explore just how marginal the position of the Rohingyas now is and thus the extent to which almost any political, environmental or economic shock could act as the trigger for genocide.

### *Build up to the 2015 elections*

As we have seen, each electoral cycle in Myanmar since 1990 has seen a further reduction in the rights of the Rohingyas. They were able to participate in the elections between independence and military rule, with some limits, and ethnic Rohingyas were elected to parliament (and continued to serve in parliament even after the imposition of military rule in 1962). In 1990, despite the loss of many rights in the intervening period, a number of Rohingyas were still allowed to vote and stand for elections, and